

Basement / Storage / Utility Area Interview

Practice Questions

(answer truthfully; don't guess if unsure).

1) Does a basement/storage/utility area exist? Where is it?

- Is there a basement, storage room, utility closet, or shared building utility area?
- How do you access it (stairs inside the home, hallway door, outside entrance)?
- Is it private to your unit or shared with other tenants?
- Is it locked? Who has the key/code?

2) General layout and what's stored there

- Describe the layout: what do you see first when you enter the space?
- What are the main items stored there (bins, shelves, boxes, luggage, tools)?
- Are items organized on shelves, on the floor, or in labeled bins?
- Any area that is off-limits or belongs to someone else (in shared spaces)?

3) Storage bins, boxes, and labeling

- Do you use plastic storage bins or cardboard boxes (or both)?
- What color are the main bins, and are any labeled?
- Where are important bins kept (front, back, left/right side)?
- Who packed/organized the storage most recently?

4) Seasonal items (common detail checks)

- Where do you keep seasonal items (holiday decorations, winter coats, fans/AC units)?
- Do you store a Christmas tree or lights here? Where exactly?
- Where do you keep seasonal sports/outdoor items (camping gear, beach chairs, etc.)?
- Do you rotate items seasonally? When did you last bring something up/down?

5) Tools and maintenance items

- Do you have a toolbox? Where is it kept?
- What basic tools do you have (screwdriver set, hammer, wrench, tape measure)?
- Do you keep paint, spackle, or wall repair supplies? Where?
- Where are batteries, light bulbs, or extension cords stored?
- Who usually handles small fixes around the home?

6) Water heater / boiler / furnace / HVAC (if present)

- Is there a water heater/boiler/furnace in the basement/utility area?

- Where is it located (which corner/side of the room)?
- Is it gas or electric (if known)?
- Have you ever needed service/maintenance? Who called (you/landlord/maintenance)?
- Is there an HVAC filter? Where is it and how often is it changed (if known)?

7) Breaker panel / electrical

- Do you know where the breaker panel is located (basement, hallway, closet)?
- Have you ever had to flip a breaker? When and why?
- Are breakers labeled? If yes, what labels do you remember?
- Who usually handles electrical issues (you vs landlord/maintenance)?

8) Plumbing and utility shutoffs (if applicable)

- Do you know where the main water shutoff is (if known)?
- Any sump pump, floor drain, or dehumidifier in the space?
- Any recent water issues (leaks, dampness, flooding)? What happened?

9) Laundry connection (if machines are here)

- Is laundry located in the basement/utility area?
- Which machines do you use (your own vs shared)? How do you pay (coins/card/app)?
- Where do you keep detergent and laundry supplies down there?

10) Safety and access habits

- How often do you go down there (weekly, monthly, rarely)?
- Who goes down more often and for what reasons?
- Is the space well-lit? Do you use a flashlight?
- Any safety items stored there (fire extinguisher, first aid kit)? Where?

11) “Reality check” questions (recent, specific)

- When was the last time you went into the basement/storage area and why?
- What did you take out or put away last time?
- Where are the most important stored items (documents, valuables) kept—if any?
- Have you moved or reorganized anything recently? What and why?

Tip: If you're not sure about a detail, it's better to say "I don't remember exactly" than to guess.